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“The evangelical prophecies over Jerusalem have been fulfilled”: Joachim of Fiore, the Jews, Fray Diego de Landa and the Maya

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Since its rediscovery in the nineteenth century, Fray Diego de Landa’s *Relación de las cosas de Yucatán* (1566?) has been essential reading for specialists in various areas of Mesoamerican or Mayan studies. In this study, however, I focus on Landa himself rather than on Maya society at the time of European contact. Specifically, I argue that Landa’s project was informed by the medieval Joachimist tradition and examine the ways this strain of millenarian thought helped to frame Fray Diego’s understanding of the importance of the Maya, the way he wrote about them and the way he treated them as leader of the church in Yucatán. Landa stands out from other Franciscan missionaries of his time because of his savage inquisitorial practices. I suggest Landa’s approach to converting the Maya is best understood as consistent with Spanish practices well established in the late Middle Ages during the period of intense conversion of the Jews.

Keywords: Diego de Landa; *Relación de las cosas de Yucatán*; Joachim of Fiore; Spanish Jews; Maya

Since its rediscovery by C.E. Brasseur de Bourbourg in 1864 and subsequent publication and republication over the course of the twentieth century, Fray Diego de Landa’s *Relación de las cosas de Yucatán* (1566?) has served as an essential source for a variety of specialists in multiple areas of Mesoamerican or Mayan studies.¹ As Matthew Restall and John F. Chuchiak IV remark in their works on the pre-contact Maya and their world, ethnohistorians, archeologists, religious historians and epigraphers have made Landa’s chronicle “so ubiquitous a reference for Mayanists as to have virtually a biblical status.”² However, since the early 1990s scholars have paid increasing critical attention to the text of the *Relación* itself, and have made advances in assessing the way Landa’s purposes as a Spanish missionary and his ideology shaped his writing and his work. Restall and Chuchiak, for example, show how risky it can be to make easy assumptions about the *Relación*’s unity and Landa’s authorship.³ For his part, Dennis Tedlock argues that favoring European sources like the *Relación* uncritically can lead to serious misinterpretations of historical facts.⁴ The aim of this article is to extend and develop this critical approach to the

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¹The list of scholars who rely on Landa’s *Relación* since the early twentieth century is long. A partial mention of some distinguished authors might begin with the historians cited in this study, such as France Scholes, Matthew Restall, and John F. Chuchiak IV. Other authors include archeologists Sylvanus Morley (in *The Ancient Maya*) and J. Eric S. Thompson (*The Civilization of the Mayas*). Landa was also cited by anthropologist Robert Redfield in his *Chan Kom: A Maya Village*. Other noted scholars of the Maya whose disciplinary specialties are hard to narrow to one field, like Linda Schele (*A Forest of Kings*) and Michael D. Coe (*The Maya*), also refer repeatedly to Landa.

²Restall and Chuchiak, “Reevaluation,” 651.

³Restall and Chuchiak, “Reevaluation,” 651.

Relación by showing that both the text of Landa's *Relación* and his actions as missionary in Yucatán reveal Landa as an especially fervent adherent to the millenarian Joachimist worldview. Moreover, I will argue, expanding on an idea expressed by Tedlock, that this mental framework led Landa to regard the Maya in much the same way as his religious brethren viewed the Jews in the late Middle Ages.⁵

Since the publication of John Leddy Phelan's seminal *The Millennial Kingdom of the Franciscans in the New World* (1970), in which the author specifically examines millenarian thought in Gerónimo de Mendieta and Christopher Columbus, it has been noted that Joachimist thought was not uncommon amongst the Observant Franciscan missionaries of Landa's day. Yet little critical attention has been directed to evidence of this worldview in Landa's *Relación*, despite the impact of Fray Diego's chronicle and his own importance as, perhaps, the most consequential churchman of his era in Yucatán.⁶ I will argue that it is only possible to understand Fray Diego's work and his behavior towards the Maya if his adherence to Joachimist millenarianism is taken into account. It is especially important because, when taken together with Observant Franciscans' traditional view of Jews, it helps to explain the singular violence of Landa's convictions and his relentless prosecution of the religious failings of Maya converts in Yucatán.

Landa on the Maya and the Jews

Landa does not regard the Maya as equivalent to Jews in any specific sense. Rather, he suspects they may be of Jewish origin and may have some comparable characteristics. But more importantly, Landa regards the Maya as the spiritual or evangelical heirs of the Jews because they occupy an analogous position in the unfolding history of Christian salvation. To put it in Jonathan Boyarin's terms, the medieval Spanish missionary's experience with the Jews prepared a conceptual paradigm for the early-modern missionary's encounter with the Natives of New Spain.⁷ Fray Diego applies this paradigm to the Maya in his life, work, and writing as almost a necessary consequence of the apocalyptic logic that drove the Spanish missionary enterprise and that drove Landa with what seems to be a particular fervor.

Myths of origin

Fray Diego begins his notes on the history of the indigenous inhabitants of the Yucatán peninsula with one rather enigmatic sentence:

Some old men of Yucatan say that they have heard from their forebears that the country was populated by a certain people who came from the East, whom God delivered by opening for them twelve roads through the sea, which, if true, means all the inhabitants of the Indies would necessarily have come from the Jews because, once past the straits of Magellan, they had to spread over more than 2000 leagues of territory now governed by Spain.⁸

⁴Tedlock, "Torture in the Archives," 139.

⁵Tedlock, "Torture in the Archives," 146–47.

⁶David E. Timmer's "Providence and Perdition" is the most notable exception to this rule and will be discussed below.

⁷Boyarin, *Unconverted Self*.

⁸Que algunos viejos de Yucatán dicen haber oído a sus pasados que pobló aquella tierra cierta gente que entró por levante, a la cual había Dios librado abriéndoles doce caminos por la mar, lo cual, si fuese verdad, era necesario que viniesen (de) judíos todos los de las Indias, porque pasado el estrecho de Magallanes se habían de ir extendiendo más de dos mil leguas de tierra que hoy gobierna España. Landa, *Relación de las cosas de Yucatán*, 48. English translations of Landa's work are my own.

Landa offers no further explicit comments on this topic. Standing on its own, this statement may not at first seem to be entirely coherent.⁹ When read in the context of a larger debate within the Spanish colonial missionary movement, however, its meaning becomes clearer and it is possible to understand better the intellectual tradition that informed the Franciscan missionary as he gathered information about the Maya.

First, it should be noted that, like the other missionary ethnographers of his day, such as Bernardino de Sahagún and Diego Durán, Landa begins by reporting from Maya informants. However, in this case, Landa's report of the ethnographic data is qualified with the tentative expression, "if true," which is significant for several reasons. For one thing, it indicates Landa does not take everything he hears from Native informants at face value. More importantly, this statement shows that, unlike his colleague Bernardino de Sahagún, Landa is not merely interested in recording and understanding what the Maya say about themselves; he is interested in the *truth* of Native origins. For Landa the truth can only be imperfectly represented in Native accounts, since they are unenlightened by God's revelation. Landa's "if true" suggests he is prepared to allow that the Maya story may be at least partially true, it is not simply a story some Maya have heard from their elders.

Yet, this "if true" marks an important division between the first half of Landa's sentence, where he seems to simply pass along ethnographic data and the second, in which Fray Diego draws conclusions about it. Before he has even completed one sentence summarizing the indigenous myth of origin in this passage, the Franciscan missionary has already altered the Maya account for his own purposes. To begin with, the Maya elders who are the ultimate source of the account, the forebears of Landa's "old men," could never have attributed the miracle of the opening of twelve routes in the sea to the Judeo-Christian god implied here.¹⁰ The attribution of the parting of these waters not to "a" god, but to "God" signals that Landa, driven by the force of his own convictions, has inserted this Maya information into his own religious cosmology.

The peopling of the Americas

With the apparent non-sequiturs that come next – first that all Native Americans must have descended from the Jews and, second, that the continent is vast – Landa alludes to a debate over the origins of the Natives of the Americas, albeit elliptically.

Naturally, scripture was the point of departure for any ancient historical inquiries, and scripture taught all humans were descended from the passengers of Noah's Ark. So, Native ancestors must have come originally from the Old World.¹¹ But who exactly migrated from the Old World to the New, how they arrived there, and when, were important questions traditional sources did not answer.

⁹The meaning of this passage may have been clearer to compilers than to modern readers. As Restall and Chuchiak have shown, the section of the manuscript from which this is taken may not have been part of any unitary document. It may not even have originally been authored by Landa. The sole surviving manuscript of Landa's work is likely a copy from the seventeenth or eighteenth century. Parts may be summary notes or highlights. Still, in my view, there is no compelling reason to suppose this passage was *not* incorporated into Landa's work by the friar. See Tozzer, *Landa's Relación*, viii, and Restall and Chuchiak, "Reevaluation," 655.

¹⁰It is possible Landa's informants, the old men themselves, referred to the Christian God. Like the missionaries who instructed them, Native converts sometimes supposed (or appeared to suppose) the Christian God had been present and working in the Americas before 1492.

¹¹Joseph de Acosta's summary of the argument is helpful. See Acosta, *Historia natural y moral*, 47.

Fray Diego's speculation that the inhabitants of the Western Hemisphere were of Jewish origin refers to a story from the Fourth Book of Esdras, according to which ten lost tribes of Israel departed Babylon and migrated far away, to unsettled lands.¹² According to Esdras, God facilitated their departure by miraculously parting the waters for them. To a believer in the Judeo-Christian tradition, the Maya reference to roads opened up in the sea by divine intervention must have seemed a tantalizing correspondence.¹³

The idea of the miraculous pathways through the water also offered an attractive solution to another considerable difficulty for sixteenth-century theories of the peopling of the Americas. Scripture indicated the great flood had taken place only a few thousand years before. Europe, Asia, and Africa would have been repopulated before settlement could begin in the Americas. How could the vast space from Alaska to Patagonia have been so densely populated in so short a time? Landa seems to suggest that if God opened up roads through the ocean by which the lost tribes could travel simultaneously to different points, the enterprise was considerably easier to conceive.

It is worth taking a moment to underline what I regard as the full significance of Landa's intellectual procedure in this passage. When considering Maya life, Landa selects and presents only data that he can grasp and express in terms of his pre-existing European and Christian ideology. Again, one of Landa's peculiar characteristics is the vehemence of his adherence to his mission. For Landa, there is no question of allowing the Maya to shape his words or vision.¹⁴ As with the myth of origin of the ten roads through the waters, Landa accepts some Maya information in, but he will always reshape it or insert it into his own conceptual system. In this respect, he should be understood as the firmest, even the most violent of the Franciscan missionaries whose purpose was, in the words of William F. Hanks, to "purge the falsehoods, the 'vomit of idolatry,' and the 'false gods' around which so much seemed to revolve, and put truth, faith, and the trinity in their place."¹⁵ Hanks goes on to point out that this process of *reducción*, or reordering of Yucatec society, inevitably led to what he calls the missionaries' dilemma: a colonial society marked by "pervasive ambiguity, ambivalence, and an almost morbid fear of the unseen and the insincere hiding beneath the appearance of truth."¹⁶ Yet, as I shall discuss below, when judging his flock's behavior and what is an acceptable form of Christianity, Landa seems unable to admit or consider ambiguity or ambivalence. Landa does feel affection for the Maya, and he admires some of their qualities. Nonetheless, it should be remembered that Landa pursued, won, and exercised power in a way that other Joachimist Franciscans like Mendieta and Sahagún did not. When he uses his authority his first priority is always to establish sincere and unambiguous conformity to his absolute model of acceptable Christian practice.

¹²*The Catholic Encyclopedia*. Vol. 5, s.v. "Esdras" (by Charles Souvay), IV.

¹³There was a still a discrepancy between the twelve Maya routes and the ten tribes.

¹⁴Several authors have contributed to a fuller understanding of colonial Yucatec history and literature by including Native voices which had previously been discounted. Matthew Restall's *Maya Conquistador* and Frances Karttunen's *Between Worlds: Interpreters, Guides, and Survivors*, on Landa's contemporary, Gaspar Antonio Chi, are cases in point. Chi is also believed to have been one of Landa's Native sources. Nevertheless, there is little evidence that Chi or other Native informants had much influence over the interpretation or structure of Landa's writing; rather, the Spaniard limited their role to providing raw information.

¹⁵Hanks, *Converting Words*, 3.

¹⁶Hanks, *Converting Words*, 4. Hanks does not specifically quote Clendinnen here, but the notion that ambiguity is a central feature of colonial society in Yucatán is perhaps best expressed by her in *Ambivalent Conquests*.

Cultural affinities

Although Spanish colonial authors usually started their studies on the question of the origins of the indigenous Americans with scripture, they did not base their conclusions on it alone. They also scrutinized what was known about both Native and ancient Old World cultures, histories and national characters, especially common vices and virtues, looking for similarities that revealed ancient affinities.

Dominican Fray Diego Durán is among those who took a line of argumentation based on cultural analogy the furthest, arguing that the Natives must be descendants of the Jews because they wore tunics and sandals,¹⁷ told stories of ancestral wandering in search of a promised land,¹⁸ and – above all – they made bloody human sacrifices, even of children,¹⁹ as Jews were thought to do in late medieval and early-modern Spain.²⁰ Much of the generally accepted reasoning on Native origins was expressed most lucidly and succinctly by Jesuit Joseph de Acosta in 1590, in his *Historia natural y moral de las Indias*.²¹ Responding to Durán,²² Acosta threw cold water on the idea that the Natives of the Americas could be descended from the Jews.²³ However, in 1607 Dominican friar Gregorio García published a lengthy and comprehensive treatise refuting key points of Acosta's position and concluding that Native Americans were, in fact, of Jewish origin.²⁴ García's book was influential enough to be reissued in 1729. As Phelan points out, one reason for the persistence of this conjecture may be "the apocalyptical mood of the Age of Discovery. If Native Americans were in reality the lost tribes, such a discovery would be convincing evidence that the world was soon to end."²⁵

Elements in Landa's text can be read as indications that he, like some of his missionary brethren, was conscious of correlations between what early-modern Spaniards believed they knew about the Jews and what he had been discovering about Maya people. For example, Landa identifies *el repudio* (the practice of setting aside or divorcing a legal wife) as one of the principal vices of the Maya.²⁶ It was also a custom held to be a peculiarly Jewish defect.²⁷

Writing and books

For Landa and his contemporaries, one of the most significant features of civilization was writing, especially when this implied using some kind of alphabet. Here too Landa – more than other chroniclers of his time – appears to indicate an important parallel between Amerindian and Jewish cultural features. Acosta cites the fact that "the Hebrews used letters; amongst the Indians there is no sign of them," to disprove the idea of Jewish origins for the Native Americans.²⁸ By contrast, one of the most important reasons for the modern fame of Landa's *Relación* is precisely that he records not only a Maya "alphabet" but also a rudimentary explanation of how

¹⁷Durán, *Historia de las Indias*, 22.

¹⁸Durán, *Historia de las Indias*, 4–5.

¹⁹Durán, *Historia de las Indias*, 8.

²⁰Trachtenberg, *Devil and the Jews*, 138.

²¹Fray Juan de Torquemada's incorporation of long passages of Acosta's work directly into his *Monarquía indiana* of 1613 is a measure of the Jesuit's influence.

²²Parry, "Juan de Tovar," 318.

²³Acosta, *Historia natural y moral*, 70.

²⁴García, *Origen de los indios*, 79–128.

²⁵Phelan, *Millennial Kingdom of the Franciscans*, 25.

²⁶Landa, *Relación*, 69.

²⁷García, *Origen de los indios*, 112.

²⁸Acosta, *Historia natural y moral*, 71. My translation. Acosta was probably not aware of Landa's manuscript or the Maya writing system.

their writing system was used to record the sounds of spoken words.²⁹ Though the Maya writing system was not alphabetical, the fact that Landa composed a table of correspondences between Maya characters and the Roman alphabet suggests one of two things. Either Landa believed Maya characters were alphabetic, like the letters in the European or Hebrew alphabet, or he did not distinguish between alphabetical writing and other forms. In either case, Landa clearly conceived of the Maya writing system as comparable to the ones that he already knew.

Religious practices

The *Relación* also records evidence that in Landa's conception, the Maya were every bit as "ceremonious" as the Jews were commonly supposed to be. Impressive Maya temples moved Landa to include drawings with detailed descriptions and to provide evidence that they were built by the Maya, not outsiders.³⁰ Landa devotes about a third of his text to detailed explanations of the Maya ritual calendar and their religious practices. He even narrates a rite of passage which he calls *bautismo* (baptism).³¹ Finally, in several passages Landa makes detailed descriptions of Maya sacrifices. To be sure, some involve human beings, but most do not. Apart from offerings of food and drink, sacrifices are most often limited to animals, some of which are burnt before an altar. Of particular interest are the blood sacrifices, including one in which men "tear the superfluous [part] of the shameful member, leaving it like the ears."³²

Limits of cultural comparison

This last element is especially important because it leads us to a crucial observation about Landa's presentation of the Maya: he is too sophisticated to recklessly conflate their specific cultural practices with those of the Jews, as Durán and García do. Landa tactfully – but very explicitly – points out that the Historian General of the Indies, Gonzalo Fernández de Oviedo, is mistaken to confuse the scars left by this procedure with Jewish circumcision.³³ Similar limits apply to other analogies. By Landa's time, of course, baptism is an essentially Christian rite, not Jewish, yet Landa hardly claims that the unconverted Maya are comparable to Christians. He does compare the Maya calendar with the Jewish one, but he also compares it to the Roman and Gregorian calendars and does so only to highlight its unique properties.³⁴ Though Fray Diego is clearly fascinated by Maya temples, he does not compare them explicitly or implicitly with Jewish temples or synagogues.

It is instructive, however, to consider what the impressions of Maya religious buildings tell us about Landa's conception of Maya origins. Alfred Tozzer is only partly right when he remarks that "Landa deserves more than passing credit for the stand he took regarding the autochthonous origin of the Maya civilization."³⁵ The missionary's "stand" is not so clear or unequivocally admiring as Tozzer seems to suggest. Fray Diego comments on Maya architecture, stating that

²⁹Landa, *Relación*, 148–49.

³⁰Landa, *Relación*, 150. Landa recounts discovering the remains of a body buried deep within a building. It was interred together with beads still used as money by the Maya in Landa's day.

³¹Landa, *Relación*, 83.

³²Landa, *Relación*, 89.

³³Landa, *Relación*, 89. Apart from oblique references like this one, there is little evidence of Landa's other intellectual influences or reading. Little is known of his early life and education, largely because most records from the house where he professed, San Juan de los Reyes in Toledo, have not survived. Alejandro Enríquez supposes, not without justification, that Landa responds to Las Casas. But, in my opinion, whether Sepúlveda had an impact on Landa's thinking is more doubtful. See Enríquez, "Theaters of Rule," 116.

³⁴Landa, *Relación*, 113.

³⁵Tozzer, *Landa's Relación*, 172, n. 900.

“to say that other nations compelled these people to such building, it is not so,”³⁶ but he goes on to claim that if ancient Natives did build the pyramids, “they were of greater strength [*más ser*] than those of today.”³⁷ This comment suggests that Landa regards the Native Americans as a degenerate race. In brief, if the Maya are descendants of the Hebrews – an idea Fray Diego neither firmly espouses nor denies – they are Jews who have fallen into a state of physical decline and spiritual depravity. The Maya themselves bear the blame for their fallen state, since they would not “let themselves be ruled by the light of the reason [God] has given them,” and continued to embrace the false religion of the devil.³⁸

Agents of salvation

The most significant way, then, in which Landa’s Maya resemble the Jews of the sixteenth century is not to be found in the specifics of their behavior or character, or even in their ancestral origins, however suggestive they may be. Where the Maya most resemble the Hebrews for Landa is in the place or role assigned to them in the evangelical history of the world. Fray Diego’s beliefs traced their origins to the prophecies of the thirteenth-century Calabrian abbot, Joachim of Fiore. They developed over time in a more particular direction amongst the Observant Franciscans of Spain, who were still engaged in the missionary effort amongst Spain’s Jews up until the very moment when new masses of unconverted souls were discovered in the New World.³⁹ As Boyarin has put it, it was in part for these reasons, and especially in Spain, that

the very process of separating out orthodox Christianity from rabbinic Judaism shaped not only Christian rhetoric and attitudes toward Jews ever after, but also dominant European stances toward difference more generally ... Treatment of Europe’s Jews also began to be systematized in ways that would sometimes serve as templates for the subsequent treatment of other forms of difference.⁴⁰

The Yucatec Maya of the sixteenth century are a perfect example. Because of his apocalyptic passion, Landa – both in what he writes about the Maya and in the way he treats them – provides especially strong evidence that the conceptual framework and practices developed in Spain to evangelize the Jews are later applied to the Maya: in Fray Diego’s case, with a zeal approaching fury.

The Franciscan Joachimist tradition

Before continuing my examination of Fray Diego’s *Relación*, however, I wish to summarize a few of the characteristics of the Joachimist tradition as it developed within the Franciscan Order, particularly in Spain. Joachim of Fiore and his followers were hardly the only apocalyptic thinkers in Christendom. Fiore’s thought and writings, however, had special resonance for the more fervent members of the Franciscan Order because one of the prophetic conclusions at which Father Joachim arrived. In his reading of scripture, Joachim held that in the third and final age of the

³⁶Landa, *Relación*, 150.

³⁷Landa, *Relación*, 151.

³⁸Landa, *Relación*, 160.

³⁹I use the term “Joachimism” to refer to any or all the various subsequent manifestations of apocalyptic thinking inspired by Joachim of Fiore.

⁴⁰Boyarin, *Unconverted Self*; 6. Boyarin treats the Spanish and/or European mentality vis-à-vis the Jews very broadly. However, as Jeremy Cohen has shown, if anything Spanish mendicant rhetoric on and treatment of the Jews were more intense than those of the general public. See Cohen, *Friars and the Jews*.

world an “angelic, seraphic order” of spiritual men, or missionaries, would miraculously convert the remaining non-Christians of the world. Naturally, the Franciscans understood this as a reference to their own Order.⁴¹

Some of Joachim’s earliest Franciscan followers were part of a particularly extreme apocalyptic faction within the Order called the Spirituals. The details are not especially important for my purposes here, as Pope John XXII declared them heretical and suppressed their writings and organization by 1328. Amongst the Franciscans, however, neither Joachimism nor conflict with the secular church ended there. Under St. Bonaventure, the Order purged enough of the most notorious offenders, together with their most objectionable ideas, to satisfy their critics in the rest of the Church. But the central tenets of Joachimist millenarism were still espoused by many Franciscans, including leaders such as St. Bonaventure himself.⁴² In general terms, these brothers made up the wing of the Order later referred to as Observant.⁴³ The Observant wing was ostensibly formed to advocate strict adherence to the poverty requirement of the Rule of 1223, but in fact, it shared the Spirituals’ ardent ideas on Franciscan purity and their seraphic role in the coming Apocalypse.

Franciscan Joachimism in Spain

The Observants are significant for the importance they acquire in Spain. By the end of the fifteenth century, one of their own – Cardinal Ximénez de Cisneros, the former Franciscan Provincial of Spain and Queen Isabella’s confessor – is Archbishop of Toledo and Chancellor of Spain. According to Phelan, Queen Isabella “entrusted Cisneros to undertake a sweeping and much-needed reform of clerical abuses. Taking his own Observants as the model, he reconstructed the regular clergy.”⁴⁴ Moreover, although Cisneros “died in 1517, the Franciscan modality embodied by him continued to shape Spanish style and practice in the conquest, especially in the religious conquest, of New Spain.”⁴⁵ Before the sixteenth century, the Observants essentially take over the now much more influential Order, with the blessing of the Crown.⁴⁶ The monastery where Diego de Landa professed before setting off for Mexico in 1549, San Juan de los Reyes, is a prominent example.⁴⁷ By 1462 or 1463 reform was under way in the Franciscan Province of Castile and the Observants were angling for control of the older house in Toledo. Instead, by 1486 all the friars were moved to the newer San Juan de los Reyes, built by Ferdinand and Isabella in 1477, which was already under the control of the Observants.⁴⁸ When Diego de Landa took his vows towards 1540, then, he joined an Order already decidedly oriented towards the Joachimist current and with a fervent missionary bent.

Attitudes towards the Jews

There was another particularly important trend taking shape in Franciscan life over the three centuries following Joachim of Fiore’s death: a darkening of views on the Jews. Father Fiore’s writing on the Jews was generally in line with the traditional, tolerant Augustinian position that they had a

⁴¹West, “Medieval Ideas of Apocalyptic Mission,” 294.

⁴²Lerner, *Feast of Saint Abraham*, 48–49.

⁴³This is an oversimplification. However, the related division between Observants and Conventuals is only indirectly related to this study.

⁴⁴Phelan, *Millennial Kingdom of the Franciscans*, 45.

⁴⁵Sylvest, *Motifs of Franciscan Mission Theory*, 24.

⁴⁶See also Bataillon, *Érasme et l’Espagne*, 4–5.

⁴⁷De La Rosa, “Bezerro general,” 109.

⁴⁸Moorman, *Medieval Franciscan Houses*, 477–78.

place in Christian society. However, he also predicted that at the end of the Second Age, which was rapidly approaching, the Jews would be miraculously converted and unite with their Christian brethren.⁴⁹ They would go on to help the Christians convert the rest of the unbelievers at the end of time.

This relatively benevolent vision began to erode almost immediately after Fiore's death. The mendicants' general attitudes against the Jews hardened in the late Middle Ages, though it is not clear why. It may have been because the Jews did not seem to be responding to their historic role as they should. The Franciscans' conception of the Jews' role in apocalyptic prophecy shifted along with these general attitudes. Where once the conversion of the Jews was a miracle to be cheerfully awaited, by John of Rupescissa's time (d. 1362) it seemed the friars had lost some of their patience and began to adopt a more militant attitude; if the Jews would not recognize and embrace their inevitable Christian mission all by themselves, forceful encouragement might be called for.⁵⁰

Missionary methods

As part of a general movement, more aggressive methods for proselytizing developed, famously including forcing the Jews to listen to Christian sermons and mass conversions carried out under the threat of mob violence. Dominican friar Ramón de Peñaforte and his followers, especially Fray Ramón Martín, developed tools that were more subtle, but ultimately just as consequential. Peñaforte's central idea was that missionaries should learn enough about the people they meant to convert so as to be able to persuade the unbelievers in their own terms. To this end, he advocated training missionaries in the intricacies of the Hebrew and Arabic languages and religious literature.⁵¹ Ramón Martín's influential *Pugio Fidei* was a remarkably erudite example of the sort of missionary resources Peñaforte had in mind and was meant to be used by missionaries to persuade Jews of the errors of rabbinic Judaism and speed their conversion, thus preparing for the coming of the new age.⁵²

At the same time, it was generally recognized that the Jews were hard-hearted by nature and not easy to persuade, even by such sophisticated instruments as the *Pugio Fidei*.⁵³ There were predictable signs that the mass conversions were not sincere in many cases, which led, of course, to the application of inquisitorial methods to discover and punish heretical backsliding.

No one was more frustrating for the mendicant missionaries than the leaders of the Jewish communities themselves, who seemed deliberately malevolent in their unwillingness to concede the truth. How could this be explained, unless the rabbis had given themselves over to the devil?⁵⁴ If the defenders of rabbinical Judaism were under the sway of the devil, then what could their Talmudic literature be but the work of the devil, too? In a curious turn, mendicant missionaries argued that the Jews used their books to defend "an evil that knows the truth it is resisting."⁵⁵ Jewish literature was said to be not merely steeped in error, but blasphemous. The mendicants used this reasoning to advocate successfully the confiscation and burning of the *Talmud* in both France and Aragon.⁵⁶ Tertiary Franciscan Ramón Llull's position on refractory

⁴⁹Lerner, *Feast of Saint Abraham*, 31.

⁵⁰Lerner, *Feast of Saint Abraham*, 79.

⁵¹Cohen, *Friars and the Jews*, 107.

⁵²Chazan, *Daggers of Faith*.

⁵³Trachtenberg, *Devil and the Jews*, 15.

⁵⁴Trachtenberg, *Devil and the Jews*, 18.

⁵⁵Boyarin, *Unconverted Self*, 75.

⁵⁶Cohen, *Friars and the Jews*, 80.

Jews was indicative of the ultimate direction in which the proselytes' frustration would lead them; he advocated trying to bring the Jews to reason. But those whom reason failed should face a stark choice: conversion or banishment.⁵⁷

The Maya and the Jews

I turn now to my assertion that, in both word and deed, Fray Diego de Landa shows that the Maya of Yucatán occupy a position similar to that of the Jews in his worldview. Landa provides ample evidence that the Natives of the New World were analogous to the Jews in two ways. First, key aspects of their quality as members of an unbelieving society called for a missionary approach similar to that adopted with the Jews in the previous century, at least in Landa's mind. Second, Landa's Joachimist vision could only be sustained if the Native Americans assumed the role previously assigned to the Jews in the coming drama of the Apocalypse.

One distinct parallel between the Jews and the Maya as objects of spiritual conquest is in the perceived pernicious character of their respective religious leaderships. The medieval friars targeted the most renowned Talmudic scholars, like Nahmanides, for aggressive debates and other forms of evangelical pressure for two reasons. First, they assumed that when they bested the leaders at the heart of the community, as they could not fail to do, ordinary Jews would convert to Christianity in droves. Second, they regarded the rabbis as cynical servants of Satan, and supposed they deserved additional confrontation.

Multiple passages in the *Relación de las cosas* show Landa regarded the Maya priests and religious authorities in the same way. Landa praises the religiosity of the common people, but laments the fact that their devotion is wasted on idolatry before their conversion. He describes Maya women, for example, as especially worthy of respect, saying that "they were very devout and ceremonious, they gave many devotions to their idols, burning incense to them, offering gifts."⁵⁸ He suggests that, given a chance, the general population would respond well to the missionaries. The problem is that even after religious training seemed to be going well, the people were "perverted by their priests they had in their idolatry and by their lords," of the old order.⁵⁹ For Fray Diego, what is behind this idolatrous rearguard action is not a sincere religiosity, but spite. The traditional priests, shamans and sorcerers, cling to their blindness, refusing to acknowledge natural law, and persist in perverting their own people because they know they are losing their grip on power with each new conversion to Christianity. Ultimately, of course, the hand of the devil is behind the lust for power and malice of the priests.

Landa constantly describes Maya religious practices as the work of the devil and the particular form his insistence takes is reminiscent of nothing so much as the popular medieval conceptions of the mysterious, diabolical skills of the Jews. Popular legend credited medieval and early-modern Jews with a special relationship to demonic forces that gave them occult powers, arcane astrological knowledge, and the ability to create magic amulets, amongst other things.⁶⁰ Landa attributes the same powers to Maya religious figures, whom Fray Diego divides into several sub-groups, including priests, witch doctors,⁶¹ and *chilanes*, who "were charged with giving the oracles of the devil."⁶² Each group derives its own special powers from the devil,

⁵⁷Cohen, *Friars and the Jews*, 225.

⁵⁸Landa, *Relación*, 100. I render Landa's *santeras* as "ceremonious," as the context suggests he refers to superstitious pagan practice.

⁵⁹Landa, *Relación*, 71.

⁶⁰Trachtenberg, *Devil and the Jews*, 74–75.

⁶¹Landa, *Relación*, 77, 89. The Spanish terms Landa uses are *hechiceros*, *médicos*, and *cirujanos*.

⁶²Landa, *Relación*, 60.

much as the various Jewish sorcerers, physicians, astrologers, and cabbalists were supposed to do. Landa credits these figures' dark "sciences" with some degree of efficacy, particularly the healers'. However, he is careful to clarify that ultimately the priests offer the people only "tricks, auguries, and deceptions."⁶³

Another characteristic the Maya shared with the Jews was their deep devotion to books that Christians regarded as diabolical. Indigenous writing, religion, knowledge, and the calendar are inextricably interwoven. In his discussion of the Maya month of Uo, for example, Fray Diego describes a ritual in which the priests mixed water with verdigris and "anointed with it the tablets of the books for their purification."⁶⁴ The Maya codices themselves, then, were objects of veneration, not unlike the *Torah* was for the Jews. This reverence for the written word is most evident in the passage where Landa comments rather flatly that "we found a great number of books in these their letters, and since they contained nothing but superstitions and falsehoods of the devil we burned them all, which they lamented in the extreme, and which caused them sorrow."⁶⁵ Fray Diego's response to the Maya veneration of their scripture, then, is the same as that of the most rabid medieval proselytes to Jewish religious scripture.

This brings us to another important point. If Landa, when confronted with the religious world of the Maya, conceived it in terms similar to the world of the Spanish Jews, then it is only logical that he and his brethren should respond with missionary methods that had been applied to the Jews before. The friars undertook intensive studies of indigenous languages and religious practices in order to assemble the tools they needed to defeat idolatry, just as Peña-forte and Llull had urged their medieval forebears to do. Landa himself was said to have improved a Yucatec Maya manual originally authored by Fray Luis de Villalpando,⁶⁶ and both the breadth and the detail of his writing on Maya religious practice in his *Relación* led France Scholes to describe him as "so thorough that his treatise has become the foundation for modern Maya research."⁶⁷

The inquisition of 1562

This brings us to a turning point in Landa's career: the inquisition of 1562. Like many of the Spanish *conversos* before them, the recently converted Maya were notable for their "obduracy," or attachment to their pre-Christian books and way of life. This is doubly understandable when one takes into account that most Maya converts had received little religious instruction, either before or after baptism. It should have surprised no one that, just like the Jews, the Maya returned clandestinely to older ways, "making sacrifices not only by incense, but also of human blood."⁶⁸ The backsliding was discovered to be significant not only in scale, but also in the gravity of the alleged offenses. Beyond the many accounts of idol worship, there were even reports that some Maya had sacrificed children after renaming them "Jesus Christ" and nailing them to crosses before removing their hearts, or killing them by other means.⁶⁹ Another account had some Maya priests nailing a pig to a cross.⁷⁰ It must have seemed to the friars that the gruesome

⁶³Landa, *Relación*, 147.

⁶⁴Landa, *Relación*, 134.

⁶⁵Landa, *Relación*, 148.

⁶⁶López de Cogolludo, *Historia de Yucathan*, 265.

⁶⁷Scholes, "Franciscan Missionary Scholars," 415.

⁶⁸Landa, *Relación*, 71.

⁶⁹Scholes, "Landa and the Problem of Idolatry," 614–17.

⁷⁰Clendinnen, *Ambivalent Conquests*, 123–24. Tedlock points out, however, that given the hysterical mood of the Franciscans, the political pressure they were under to justify their harsh response to the heresy, and the

medieval folk tales of diabolical Jewish practices involving body parts and deliberate mockery of Christian sacraments had all resurfaced amongst the Maya of Yucatán.

Landa, by then at the head of the new Franciscan Province of San José, responded exactly as he might have to Spanish Judaizers, by launching an inquisitorial process. Landa's own description of his inquisition is rather mild. He states simply that

the friars held an inquisition, and they asked for the help of the *alcalde mayor* in catching many and putting them on trial; and an *auto* was celebrated, putting many on scaffolds, capped, flogged and shorn, and some put in the penitential robes for a time; and others, out of sadness, and deceived by the devil, hanged themselves.⁷¹

By all other accounts, it was an extraordinarily brutal affair, even by the standards of the Spanish Inquisition. Landa and the rest of the friars rounded up hundreds of Maya and made liberal use of torture to procure testimony and confessions. Many later recanted, alleging they had only cooperated to escape torment. The friars paid little attention even to the feeble legal protections and procedures established by the Holy Office. Moreover, many important Maya chiefs or other notables were caught up in the arrests and there was considerable risk that the strain might lead to desperate Maya responses, including rebellion.

Alarmed, Spanish colonists and the province's first bishop, Francisco de Toral, who arrived in Mérida at the height of the prosecutions, denounced Landa's excesses to the proper authorities in Mexico and Spain. Fray Diego already had a long string of victories in struggles with Spanish settlers behind him, and was nothing if not a persistent and skillful infighter. In 1563 he returned to Spain to defend himself and the other missionaries. During these years, Landa probably wrote in Spain some passages of the *Relación*, if only to justify himself.⁷² The matter was referred to Landa's home Franciscan Province of Castile. In the end, Landa was not only exonerated, but when Toral passed away, he was appointed to replace him as bishop of Yucatán.

Explaining Landa's harshness

The persistence and vehemence of Fray Diego's inquisition has long puzzled scholars who have tried to reconcile the savagery of the Franciscan's witch hunt with the affection and admiration he expressed for his Maya flock under other circumstances. Scholes' explanation is that "Landa was a missionary priest first and last. His major purpose in life was to advance the Christian faith. His actions in 1562 and his policies as bishop were directed toward the same end."⁷³ Inga Clendinnen speculates that Landa reacted emotionally. Confronted with the extent of the secret apostasy of the Maya, even among individuals he had come to trust personally, Fray Diego "concluded that they had betrayed him," and lashed out.⁷⁴ John Chuchiak's interpretation, based on Bishop Landa's extension of the anti-idolatry campaign into the 1570s after his return from Spain, suggests

fact that the most lurid accusations were obtained under torture, most, if not all of these tales are suspicious, just like the tales told about the diabolical behavior of the Jews in Spain. See Tedlock, "Torture in the Archives," 146–47.

⁷¹Los frailes hicieron inquisición y pidieron la ayuda del *alcalde mayor* prendiendo a muchos y haciéndoles procesos; y se celebró un *auto* en que pusieron muchos en cadalsos encorrozados, y azotados y trasquilados y algunos ensambenitados por algún tiempo; y otros, de tristeza, engañados por el demonio, se ahorcaron. Landa, *Relación*, 71.

⁷²However, as Restall and Chuchiak have shown, much of the document may have been compiled at other times, for other purposes or elsewhere. See "Reevaluation."

⁷³Scholes, "Franciscan Missionary Scholars," 415.

⁷⁴Clendinnen, *Ambivalent Conquests*, 123.

that Landa was driven both by his controlling nature and by an unswerving devotion to his Order. Chuchiak argues Landa believed the Franciscans should maintain total authority over the Maya, to the exclusion of the secular clergy and civil government.⁷⁵

All these authors are surely right to some degree. However, they do not fully explain Fray Diego's persistent fervor. Landa's relentless prosecution of backsliding was uncommon, even in other equally dedicated missionaries. In fact, as Patricia Lopes has shown, the Spanish Council of Indies prohibited in 1543 the application of severe, inquisitorial procedures to the Indians of New Spain because it was feared they would be counterproductive. Landa was in Mexico City between 1549 and 1551 and must have been aware of the controversy and the Council's wishes. His antagonist, Francisco de Toral, who served as Franciscan Provincial in Mexico City before his appointment as bishop of Yucatán, would certainly also have known.⁷⁶ Again, Toral, Mendieta, Sahagún, Motolinía, and other Franciscan missionaries of the time did not carry out the kind of inquisition Landa did, although – it must be noted – most of them did not have the power to do so. In any case, explaining Landa's singular behavior fully is a difficult but important proposition.

Clendinnen may well be right that Landa suffered from a deep sense of personal betrayal, at least initially, and that these feelings may have contributed to the severity of his reaction against the Maya. However, it seems unlikely such feelings, no matter how acute, could have sustained the force of the extirpation campaign as late as the 1570s, after Landa had returned from Spain to take his place as bishop. Moreover, though Chuchiak shows convincingly that Landa devoted constant attention to shutting secular clergy and authorities out of Yucatán, he does not fully explain what drove him to do so.⁷⁷ Had Fray Diego been motivated solely by lust for power, why would he have continued to dismantle the secular clerical apparatus of the diocese even after he was appointed bishop? Why did he continue to favor the Franciscans and resume the harsh campaign against idolatry after his triumphant return to Yucatán?

The importance of Landa's Joachimist convictions

David E. Timmer argues convincingly that the simplest and most satisfying explanation for Landa's extreme treatment of the Maya is his adherence to apocalyptic convictions.⁷⁸ Timmer does not attribute particular importance to Joachimist thought. He characterizes Franciscan millenarism generally (and Landa's especially) as a "tangled mass of roots," rather than an identifiable tradition.⁷⁹ Nevertheless, although Father Joachim of Fiore's thought was surely not the only root of Franciscan apocalyptic thought in the sixteenth century, there is reason to believe it was an especially important one. As he writes years before Chuchiak's work, Timmer does not address the question of why Landa fought so resolutely – and successfully – against the establishment of the secular clergy in Yucatán. However, if one assumes Landa's thought is steeped in Joachimism, this aspect becomes clearer. Since Pope John XXII's suppression of the Spirituals' heretical association of the secular church with the antichrist, the Observant Franciscans had learned to be somewhat cautious about denouncing what they saw as the corruption of the rest of the church. In any case, that did not prevent them from continuing to believe Joachim had prophesized that their Order would have a providential leading role in the final Christian evangelization of the world.

⁷⁵Chuchiak, "In Servitio Dei," 644.

⁷⁶See Lopes, "Franciscans."

⁷⁷Chuchiak, "In Servitio Dei."

⁷⁸Timmer, "Providence and Perdition."

⁷⁹Timmer, "Providence and Perdition," 481.

Landa may or may not have resisted commending the freshly converted souls of the Natives to the secular clergy because of clerical corruption. His *Relación* is prudently silent on that issue. However, he does make clear how important and special the role of the missionary priests was. In the rest of the book he made little mention of the king, and portrayed the Spanish colonists in a very negative light, as he devoted an entire chapter to the ways in which the Franciscans protected the Maya against the abuses of the Spanish settlers. The only parties that Landa describes as having providential, specific parts to play are Christopher Columbus and the friars. The continuing ministry and persistent correction of the religious missionaries truly effect God's divine purpose. In fact, he says quite explicitly that "justice has drawn [the Indians] from [their errors] by the preaching" of the missionaries.⁸⁰

Fray Diego makes the apocalyptic implications of his missionary activity more explicit in a crucial introduction to his discussion of the Maya calendar, religious rites and writing. He also makes it clear how his Joachimist orientation compels him to take stern action against the backsliding Natives.

This passage's singular style sets it apart from most of the *Relación* and signals its importance to Fray Diego. Throughout most of the book, Landa's language is abbreviated, plain and simple. Most items are marked with the initial anaphora "Que ...," which functions as a kind of verbal bullet point.⁸¹ Only in a few passages, such as the said introduction to the Maya calendar, does Landa's language show that he is trying to express strong feelings, or appeal to those of the reader. The introduction takes the form of a prayer directed to God on behalf of the reader. It begins with an exhortation concerning the Maya, in which Landa directs the readers to "implore [God] for their preservation and progress in good Christianity."⁸²

Next, still praying for the Maya, Fray Diego asks that they might not falter in the progress they have made, fall back into error or worse, return "the houses of their souls" to the devil.⁸³ Here, Landa means to stress how important it is not to allow the Maya to return to their idolatry, or persist in it. He also justifies the rough justice he had administered as inquisitor. But his next words show that he is doing more than that. Referring to the possibility of Native apostasy, Landa mentions that backsliding is no vain fear:

Seeing the perdition which for so many years there has been in the great and very Christian Asia, in the good, Catholic, and most august Africa, and the miseries and calamities which today occur in our Europe and in our nation and houses, for which we might say that the evangelical prophecies over Jerusalem have been fulfilled for us, where her enemies would encircle her and sap and squeeze her so that they might overthrow her; and this God would have already allowed [to befall us], sinners that we are, but that His church cannot fail, nor can what was said [be unfulfilled]: *Dominus reliquisset semen sicut Sodoma fuisset.*⁸⁴

⁸⁰Landa, *Relación*, 182.

⁸¹Citing Restall and Chuchiak, Enríquez notes that the repeated use of *que* sounds legalistic, which may have led some authors to conclude that Landa composed the *Relación* as part of his legal defense against accusations of abuse of office. It is more likely, however, that Landa was simply uninterested in adorning these points with rhetorical flourishes or that he was more expansive on these points in his original text and the manuscript copy was partly made up of abbreviated notes. See Enríquez, "Theaters of Rule," 163.

⁸²Landa, *Relación*, 113.

⁸³Landa, *Relación*, 113.

⁸⁴Viendo la perdición que hace tantos años hay en toda la grande y muy Cristiana Asia, y en la Buena y católica y augustísima África, y las miserias y calamidades que el día de hoy pasan en nuestra Europa y en nuestra nación y casas, por lo cual podríamos decir se nos han cumplido las evangélicas profecías sobre Jerusalén de que la cercarían sus enemigos y la agostarían y apretarían tanto que la derrocasen por tierra; y esto ya lo habría permitido Dios, según somos, pero no puede faltar su iglesia ni lo del que dijo *Dominus reliquisset semen, sicut Sodoma fuisset.* Landa, *Relación*, 113–14.

For Landa, the conversion of the Maya is inseparable from progress towards the fulfillment of apocalyptic prophecy. Moreover, the crucial importance of the successful and sincere conversion of the Native Americans also becomes clear in this passage. Landa seems to have little hope that the Church will survive in the Old World. Its cradle in the Holy Land has long fallen to Muslim invaders. So have Asia and Africa. The heart of Christendom, Europe, is also threatened by the Turks in the East and, worse, is home to heretical Protestants in the north and seems ready to succumb to calamity at any moment. The vague reference to “our nation and houses” is interesting in that it would seem to indicate that Landa feels that even the Christianity of Catholic Spain is questionable.⁸⁵

Given all of this, America is the Church’s last redoubt. Only through the successful conversion of its indigenous inhabitants is there any hope that Christianity will break out of its state of siege and achieve its final triumph as foretold by evangelical prophecy. The scriptural quotation from Romans 9:29 confirms this.⁸⁶ The allusion is particularly meaningful in this context. The original verse suggests that if God had not provided for a few righteous survivors (the “seed”) to be preserved, the whole of Israel might have been wiped out for its wickedness, just as Sodom and Gomorrah were. Of course, when Paul uses the phrase in his Letter to the Romans, he really means to apply it to Israel’s successors, the Christians. Landa does, too.⁸⁷ He means to say that Christianity has fallen into such a state of pre-apocalyptic disgrace that if God had not chosen to preserve its “seed” amongst the Native Americans, it would surely perish as well. In this way, the role of the Natives is analogous to the triumphal role Joachim foresaw for the Jews at the end of the Second Age.

Given the conceptual frame within which Fray Diego is operating, the implacable character of his sustained, frontal assaults on both indigenous religious practice and ecclesiastical rivals is easier to understand. For Landa, both the Franciscans and the Natives are vitally important. Only the Franciscans can lead mankind to the Age of the Spirit at the end of time. And the struggle against Native apostasy is not just an important question, but an existential one (and not just for the Maya themselves, but for all humanity). If the indigenous people of the Americas are the “seed,” they must be converted *and* preserved in righteousness, or the last hope of Christendom will be destroyed. Without the Maya converts taking their place amongst the Christian forces, God’s plan for salvation of all humanity might not come to fruition.

To someone who believed that so much was at stake there was no good reason to slow down the campaign to extirpate idolatry. In Fray Diego’s view, what should really move one to pity is not the suffering of a witness forced to accuse another of idolatry, but rather “so many multitudes walking towards hell” by lapsing back into their old religion.⁸⁸ Landa clarifies this in another of the rare passages of the *Relación* in which he adopts a passionate, prayerful tone. Here, Landa addresses God directly:

[Y]ou are he of whom the prophet said, when full of your most holy spirit, that you make false burdens of your commandments, and so it is, Lord, that those who have not taken pleasure in the lightness of

⁸⁵Doubtless, Landa does not elaborate because doing so could be dangerous.

⁸⁶In Romans 9:29 Paul quotes Isaiah 1:9. Since Landa’s citation is abbreviated, it is impossible to tell by the text alone which passage Fray Diego refers to. Either way, however, the significance of the passage as it relates to Landa’s idea is the same.

⁸⁷This quote is especially attractive for a Joachimist because Fiore’s prophetic method was based on seeking parallels between the Old and New Testaments and projecting the patterns on to the future. See Lerner on the “concordance of testaments,” *Feast of Saint Abraham*, 12–13.

⁸⁸Landa, *Relación*, 160.

the keeping and fulfillment of your precepts, find a burden in them; but, Lord, it is a false burden, a burden of fear, a burden to the pusillanimous.⁸⁹

The Maya converts may find the rigors of true religion an affliction, but that is nothing compared to the cruelty of their false cult. In fact, any burden shouldered in God's name is not really a burden. Of course, by extension this logic tends to excuse Landa for the suffering caused by the rigors of the inquisition of 1562. He suggests the burdens he placed on his Maya flock should also be considered false or merely pretended.

Conclusion

To conclude, I have argued that there was a deep ambivalence at the heart of Landa's millenarian conception of the Maya which informed both the way he understood the Maya and the way he wrote about them. This ambivalence was born of his apocalyptic worldview, of the medieval Joachimist tradition, in that it led to a vision of the Maya comparable to Spanish missionary views of the converted Jews.⁹⁰ On the one hand, the Maya were considered the great hope for all mankind and inspired admiration. This drove Landa to record the signs of an ancient civilization which originated among the Chosen People, and what he regarded as Maya versions of sacraments such as baptism and confession.

On the other hand, however, the immediate Maya past, just like that of the Jews, showed disturbing signs of barbarity, even inhumanity, and was marked by rejection of natural law and service to the devil. Landa responded to this side of Maya culture by carefully recording the outward features of their idolatrous practices, including the modalities of human sacrifice.

From his vantage point at what he considered the Eleventh Hour, Fray Diego also saw the future of the Natives, much like that of the Jews of Spain, as ambivalent. Christianity needed the indigenous people and was dependent on their sincere conversion. Yet their backsliding, like that of the *conversos*, showed their weakness and the risk that they would fall into depravity, with disastrous consequences for all creation. They therefore needed the indulgence and the tutelage of the Spanish missionaries in order to fulfill their role in the coming apocalyptic struggle for salvation. This is why Landa had to keep a careful balance in what he said about Maya idolatry in his *Relación*. On the one hand, he defended his inquisition – leaving out the details about the most extreme measures – and highlighted the evil influences of Maya priests and leaders. On the other, he minimized the culpability of the greater portion of the Maya population.⁹¹ When Landa wrote about the worst Maya practices, he interspersed these passages with exhortations to the reader to “favor and help” them, explaining why it was necessary.

Though these passages are relatively brief, they are crucial for understanding Landa and the *Relación*. In his account of the history, culture, and religion of the Maya, more than anything else he was trying to explain the importance and potential benefit to all the world of saving the Maya

⁸⁹[T]ú eres aquel de quien dijo el profeta lleno de tu santísimo espíritu, que finges trabajo en tu mandamiento, y es así señor, que los que no han gustado de la suavidad de la guarda y cumplimiento de tus preceptos, trabajo hallan en ellos; pero, señor, trabajo fingido es, trabajo temido es, trabajo de pusilánimes es. Landa, *Relación*, 160.

⁹⁰The ambivalence to which I refer here differs from the subject of Inga Clendinnen's study of colonial Yucatán, *Ambivalent Conquests*. Clendinnen (and Hanks, amongst others) is concerned with the inevitably incomplete state and ambiguous character of the conversion or transformation of Maya subjects into colonial, Christian ones. Rather, I refer to Landa's apparently bifurcated internal vision of the nature of the Maya and their role in the future of Christian salvation.

⁹¹The Maya crucifixions of children and animals are not recorded in the *Relación*, but are in other sources.

from themselves. He also meant to explain the potential calamity of letting them sink into idolatry. Every word, directly or indirectly, was written to communicate the fundamental importance of the mission to the Maya and their potential role in the redemption of all humanity by fulfilling the evangelical prophecies which had inspired Franciscan missionaries like Landa since the Middle Ages.

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